



# Career Development Program

For Non-Traditional Higher Education Learners



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# What is a non-traditional higher education student?

**An individual who did not follow a “traditional” path of entering college after high school graduation**



## Common Characteristics

- Age 25 or older
- Work full-time
- Parents/have dependents
- Financially independent
- Active military or military veterans
- Enrolled part-time
- Do not have a traditional high school diploma

# Barriers

**Financial Strain**

**Lack of Community**

**Lack of Institutional  
Support**

**Workload and Time  
Constraints**

**Lack of Technological  
Literacy/Access**





# Existing Interventions



## Prior Learning Assessments

- Also known as Credit for Prior Learning (CPL)
- Awards academic credit for prior work, military, and life experience
- Students earn credit through:
  - Exams (standardized or college-specific)
  - Portfolios
  - Evaluation of non-college or non-credit programs

(Al-Malood, 2023)

## Competency-Based Education

- Students advance by demonstrating mastery of specific skills and knowledge
- Increased from 20 programs in 2012 to over 500 programs in 2017
- Flexible, self-paced environment for students
- “Subscription” model for tuition
- UMass Global
  - MyPath

(Pluff & Weiss, 2022)

# Existing Interventions



## Career Pathway Programs

- Step-by-step, structured program to help students move from education into a career field
- Stackable credentials
  - Sequence of education or certifications that accumulate to “stack” towards higher degrees
  - CNA → LPN → RN
- Can pause training and return later
- Pay for smaller portions of education

(Fein, 2012)

## Cooperative Education Programs

- Allows students to alternate semesters of academic study with full-time, paid work experience in their chosen field
- Gain both experience and income
- Three semesters of full-time work with the same employer
- Georgia Tech Co-op Program
  - Delta, Coca-Cola, Cox

(Haddara & Skanes, 2007)



# Existing Interventions



## Scholarships and Grants

- Osher Reentry Scholarship
- ASIST Scholarship
- Pell Grant
- Jeanette Rankin National Scholar Grant
- Tennessee HOPE Scholarship for Non-Traditional Students

(Collegescholarships.org, 2026)

## Association for Non-traditional Students in Higher Education (ANTSHE)

- Founded in 1997
- Works with affiliated colleges and universities to provide resources, research, and support for non-traditional students and faculty
- Goal - improve retention and completion rates
- Informal support system for networking and collaboration

(Association for Nontraditional Students in Higher Education, 2026)

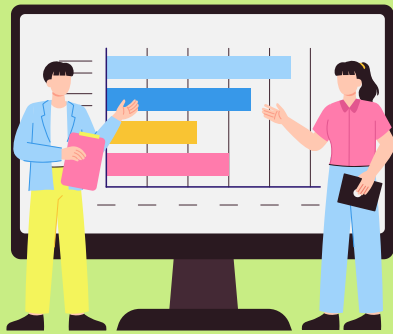


# The Proposal: Career Entry/Rentry Bootcamp

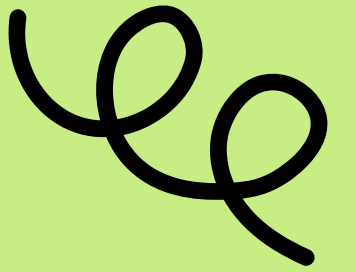
Optional 1 credit course

This bootcamp will be housed at a local college/community college. It is optional and free, part of a new student orientation (paid for by student fees). The class will walk students through entering or re-entering the career field as non-traditional higher education students. Students will have the ability to meet virtually or in person according to their group circumstances.





# Goals:



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1. Increase Career Self-Efficacy

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2. Improve Career Readiness Skills

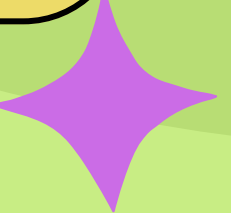
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3. Increase Sense of Community & Connectedness

1. 100% of students will discover or identify 3 transferrable skills from prior life experience.

2. 100% of students will create a professional resume, LinkedIn profile and complete a mock interview as a candidate.

3. 80% of students will network within their cohort/group and participate in:  
a. 3 structured peer interactions  
b. contribute to at least one group reflection per session/class



# Theories



This intervention is informed by 3 main theories with foundational support of Holland's RAISEC model

## Savickas

### Career Construction Theory

- Focus on: adaptability, identity and life themes.
- Activities such as storytelling and social meaning-making
- Career planning and role integration

(Savickas, 2013)

## Super

### Lifespan Theory

- Career development is ongoing & cyclical.
- Supports peer connection among individuals in similar role conflicts
- Recognizes NT learners as being in a recycling stage of exploration and establishment (i.e., second or third careers)

(Super, 1990)

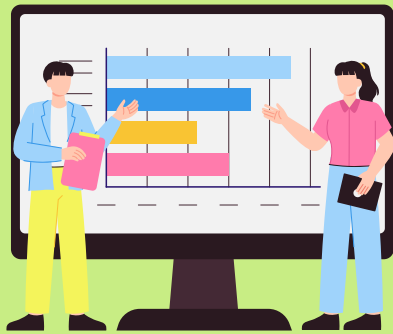
## Lent & Brown

### Social Cognitive Theory

- Supports self-efficacy and learning through modeling.
- Reinforces the importance of peer modeling and encouragement within a cohort/group.

(Lent et. al., 1994)

(Holland, 1994)



# Assessments



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RAISEC - SII, SDS and or CAI.

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Myers Briggs

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Values Matching Tool &  
Program Survey

- Interest and career development:  
a RAISEC model assessment.

(Holland, 1994)

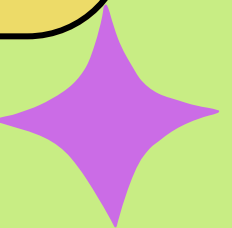
- Personality/identity: MBTI

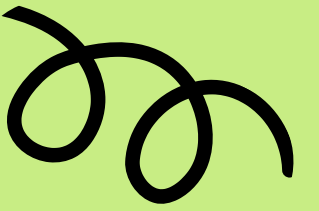
(Myers et. al, 1998)

- Values: values matching tool  
online

(CareerOneStop, n.d.)

- Peer connection, community,  
comfort engaging = Program  
survey pre/post





# Activities

Strategies for facilitating skill development, life/work planning and community building strategies

## Career Storytelling & Strength Identification

- Assessments (see previous)
- Pre-survey
- Small group Career storytelling

## Skill Development

- Resume and coverletter workshop
- Mock interviews
- Networking practice via role play
- Group-based problem solving
- Skills Workshop (including Technology Skills)

## Education Plans

- Explore resources
- Academic advisement
- Info session
- Small Group on balancing work, family etc.

## Life/Work Planning & Management

- Time management and goal setting
- Work-life balance maps
- Peer discussion on managing multiple roles
- Strategies for overcoming common barriers

## Community Building

- Cohort / group model
- Group networking
- Group reflection activity

## Experiential Opportunities

- Panel interviews
- Job shadowing / mentorship
- LinkedIn / networking activity
- Employer panel

# ETHICAL CONSIDERATIONS

How can we support diverse life paths through ethically sound career counseling?

When working with non-traditional learners, certain ethical considerations are essential. It is the counselors responsibility to identify bias and systemic inequality in order to be fair and just.

Counselors have to take into account the unique challenges faced by this population, as they enter higher education after navigating life outside of the conventional path towards a career.





# Ethical Considerations for Non-Traditional Learners

**Ensuring Access, Accommodation, and Adaptability**

## Be Fair and Flexible

Non-traditional learners balance more than your traditional learner. They may be balancing work, families, other life tasks, and education. Rigid expectations would be ethically inappropriate. (Stamou et al., 2024)

## Focus on Inclusion

Some challenges this population may face include financial strain, lack of support, and time constraint. This can stand in the way of inclusion and fair access to traditional career development.

## Access and Accommodations

Higher education systems are traditionally designed in a way that only caters to traditional students. Accommodations must be made where non-traditional learners are involved. (Chen, 2017)

# Ethical Career Counseling for Non-Traditional Learners Require:



**Flexibility in program delivery and expectations**

**Recognition of lived experience as a strength**

**Avoidance of deficit-based assumptions**



# ✧ How Our Program Responds to Student Needs

## Program Design

- **Flexible Format**
  - Offers equal opportunity (Stamou et al., 2024)
- **Cohort Model**
  - Encouraging relatability and community building
- **Focus on Career Readiness**
  - Allowing access to opportunities

## Counseling

- **Storytelling**
  - Honoring and celebrating their life experiences (Byars-Winston & Fouad, 2006)
- **Skills Workshops**
  - Building self-efficacy and self-confidence (Lee, 2025)
- **Peer Responsiveness**
  - Relationship building to reduce isolation and encourage understanding

## Evaluation

- **Pre and Post Surveys**
- **Follow-up Data**
- **Keep Participation Voluntary and Respect Confidentiality**

KEY TAKEAWAY

Our program is intentional and ethically responsive keeping in mind systemic barriers impacting non-traditional learners.



# MULTICULTURAL CONSIDERATIONS

How can we support diverse life paths  
through cultural responsiveness?

Non-traditional learners are a highly diverse population.  
Their path is paved by cultural, social, and systemic  
influences.

This increases the need for multiculturally responsive  
counseling. Understanding and acknowledging context  
is important to provide support that is inclusive, fair, and  
allows equal opportunity to different career pathways.





# Multicultural Considerations for Non-Traditional Learners

Celebrating Diversity,  
Inclusivity, and  
Individuality

## Unique Experiences and Identities

This population is diverse and includes working adults, parents with unique family needs/responsibilities, and people from diverse socioeconomic and cultural backgrounds. (Chen, 2017)

## Forgotten Population

Higher education institutes often overlook the needs of non-traditional learners, despite their growing representation in higher education. (Chen, 2017)

## Understanding Culture

Counseling must be culturally responsive especially when it comes to career development. (Byars-Winston & Fouad, 2006)

# Multicultural Considerations for Non-Traditional Learners

Celebrating Diversity,  
Inclusivity, and  
Individuality

## Discrimination

Institutions often prioritize traditional learners, often overlooking the unique needs of non-traditional learners. This can lead to a lack of recognition for their prior life and professional experience and current life circumstances. (Chen, 2017; Stamou et al., 2024)

## Culturally Responsive Support

It is important for counselors to adapt their counseling to reflect their students'/clients' unique dispositions.

# How Our Program is Multiculturally Responsive

## The Program

- **Virtual + In-Person**
  - Supporting diverse life circumstances (Stamou et al., 2024)
- **Optional 1 Credit Format**
  - Creating space for employed students
- **Focus on Career Readiness**
  - Promoting access to diverse opportunities

## Flexible Counseling

- **Storytelling**
  - Allows sharing cultural and personal stories (Byars-Winston & Fouad, 2006)
- **Celebrating Strength**
  - Valuing lived experience as strength
- **Skill Building**
  - Supporting diverse career pathways and goals

## Community and Belonging

- **Cohort model**
  - Building connection and belonging
- **Networking Opportunities**
  - Strengthening and diversifying professional networks
- **Group Reflection**
  - Shared affinity and understanding

KEY TAKEAWAY

Our program is intentional in creating an inclusive and culturally responsive space that reflects the diverse realities of non-traditional learners.



# ADVOCACY STRATEGIES

Promoting Equity and Opportunity  
Through Career and Educational  
Advocacy

In order to create equal access and opportunities for both education and career, it is essential to advocate that systemic barriers be addressed.

Counselors can pave the way in encouraging and promoting expansive career support, flexible practices, and help identify pathways to preferred employment. Through advocacy we can reform systems to better meet the needs of diverse adult learners.



# Advocacy for Career, Educational, and Employment Success

## INSTITUTIONAL

- Advocate for flexibility in scheduling (evening, online, hybrid).
- Advocate for recognition life and career experience.
- Offer access to career counseling tailored to their unique needs.

(Chen, 2017; Stamou et al., 2024)

## EQUITY & SOCIAL JUSTICE

- Acknowledge and address systemic barriers that limit access to education and employment.
- Advocate for awareness financial support, such as financial aid, scholarships, etc.
- Promote access to meaningful and long-term employment.

(Maree, 2020)

## CAREER & WORKFORCE

- Develop relationships with employers to create opportunities.
- Identify and provide access to internships, mentorship, and networking support.
- Arrange access to career possibilities while considering adult learners' goals and life responsibilities. (Lee, 2025)

## KEY TAKEAWAY

**Effective advocacy works towards transforming systems that create barriers instead of simply supporting individual students.**



# EVALUATION

## (a) What method of evaluation will you use?

Mixed-methods evaluation design:

- Pre/Post assessments for students to assess the effectiveness of the Career Entry/Re-entry bootcamp:

  - Likert scale: (career clarity, self-efficacy, ability to identify transferable skills)

- Program-specific post-intervention peer survey

  - Likert/ qualitative short response: (peer connection, perceived support, and comfort in engaging)

- Program-specific cohort group reflection

- Pre/Post assessments to for faculty and staff

  - Confidence in supporting/ awareness of nontraditional student needs

- Facilitator observations/skill-based performance

  - Engagement, skill application, and participation

- Follow-up surveys (6-12 months post-program)

## (b) What units of measure or data will you use to evaluate effectiveness?

- Career self-efficacy

- Career readiness

- Transferable skill identification

- Career clarity

- Community/connectedness/belonging

- System and behavior level outcomes (enrollment, program/job pursuit)

- Peer connection

- Life/work management

- Role integration

- Perceived support

- Comfort with group engagement

- Faculty/staff confidence in supporting nontraditional students





# How will we know if this program was effective?

## Students:

- Increase of pre to post scores (Career self efficacy, career clarity, career readiness)
- Increased sense of belonging, community, or connectedness (participation in small group, activities, events)
- Ability to identify 3 or more transferable skills
- Increase of positive qualitative feedback: motivation, balance/integration of life roles, confidence in career direction.
- Career readiness skill attainment (successful completion of resume, LinkedIn, and cover letter and participation in mock interviews)

## Faculty/Staff:

- Increase confidence in supporting nontraditional students
- Greater awareness for student needs

## System and behavior:

- Increase of non-traditional institutional support and awareness.
- Increase of nontraditional student enrollment and job pursuit
- Increased participation in career development activities

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